



This illustration shows the bombardment of Alexandria—a sea battle won by the British, who succeeded in destroying the port's fortified batteries.

**OVER THE COURSE OF THE PREVIOUS FEW YEARS**, the power of French and British interests had grown substantially in Egypt. This led to increasing European interference in Egyptian affairs—considered legitimate because of the financial debt Egypt owed to Britain and France. By 1882, Egypt was bankrupt and the khedive (viceroy) was scarcely able to hold on to his own authority. Ismail Pasha (1830–95) had been deposed by the Ottoman sultan in 1879—under pressure from Britain and France—in favor of his son, Muhammad Tawfiq Pasha (1852–92). This **Dual Control** by the French and British persisted while there was growing internal nationalist unrest.

Britain was fearful of what a nationalist uprising might mean for the Suez Canal, in which it had a substantial interest. So British forces decided to mount an attack to stifle any further action; the Royal Navy bombarded the forts of **Alexandria** on July 11, 1882. Egypt was then placed under military occupation, becoming a British protectorate.

Farther south, in **Sudan**, British troops were continuing to fight the **Sudanese War** (1881–99) against the followers of the powerful **Muhammad Ahmad bin Abd Allah** (1844–85), who had declared a holy war after taking the title Mahdi. His mission was to restore justice to the world, believing it was soon going to end.

In Europe, an **anti-French union** was being formed, known as the **Triple Alliance**. It

consisted of Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy. The first two had signed previous unions (see 1873), which included Russia. Italy joined after disputing France's territorial claims in North Africa.

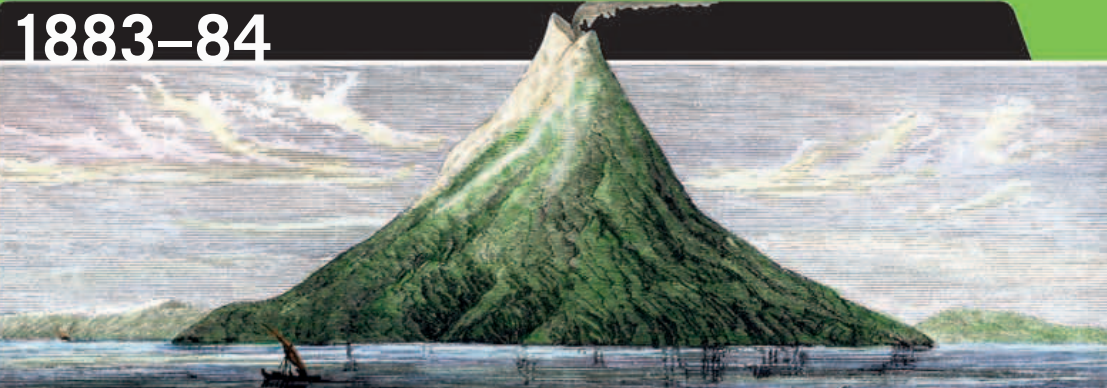
Meanwhile, in France, scientist **Louis Pasteur** (1822–95)—known for his development in 1863 of the **pasteurization** process that reduced harmful germs in food and drink—had turned his attention to vaccines (see 1796). He investigated anthrax, a bacterial disease that had killed many sheep in Europe and also affected humans. By 1881, he had conducted successful large-scale experiments with animals, and vaccines were produced.

#### BRITISH TROOPS SUFFERED EARLY DEFEATS IN THE WAR IN SUDAN

At the hands of the **Mahdi** revolutionary army (see 1882). At the beginning of the year on January 26, Ahmad and the Mahdi troops captured the city of El Obeid, situated in the center of the territory. Mahdi troops continued their march toward **Khartoum**, which had earlier been placed under British administration by the Egyptian khedive (see 1874), capturing the city after a siege of nine months.

#### Brooklyn Bridge

*The Great East River Suspension Bridge in New York City was built between 1870 and 1883. It stretches 5,988 ft (1,825 m) across its span.*



A hand-colored woodcut showing the island of Krakatoa, Indonesia, before its destruction, when its volcano erupted in 1883.

Meanwhile, France had seized more of the territory around the **Niger River** (Niger) and became involved in conflict on the island of Madagascar off the coast of East Africa in a bid to protect French territory. In 1883, France invaded the island in the **Franco-Hova War** against the Hova people—the largest Malagasy group on the island—and bombarded the coastal towns of Majunga and Tamatave from the sea. In 1885, they reached a settlement allowing the French occupation at Diégo-Suarez in the north. However, tensions continued and the French sent in 15,000 troops in 1885, landing at Majunga and capturing the capital.

Triggered by the ongoing **Berlin Conference on Africa** (see 1885) Germany claimed territory in southwest Africa (Namibia), Togoland (Togo), Cameroon, and part of the island of Zanzibar off the coast of Tanzania, East Africa. **Italy** took control of Eritrean coastal towns along the Red Sea, though made no farther inroads into **Ethiopian** territory.

In the **Pacific**, Britain and Germany divided up more territories. By the 1870s, Britain had established settlements along the coast of the eastern half of **New Guinea** (present-day Papua New Guinea), annexing it by 1884. Germany took control of the northeast part of the island.



**March 20** Britain enters Liberia demanding land is ceded to British  
**Sierra Leone**

**May 20** Triple Alliance formed between Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy

**July** Boers create Republic of Stellaland in present-day North West Province, **South Africa**

**June 11** Urabi revolt against khedive and European powers in **Egypt**

**July 11** British occupy **Egypt**

**August 20** Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky's 1812 Overture debuts in Moscow

**September 1** Kimberley, **South Africa**, becomes first town in Africa to be lit by electricity

**1883** Start of French conquest of **Madagascar**; France takes **Niger** occupying Agadez (to 1904)

**October 20, 1883** War of Pacific; Peru leaves conflict after Treaty of Ancon with **Chile**

**1884** British inventor Hiram Maxim (1840–1916) invents Maxim gun, first self-powered machine gun

**August 26, 1883** Volcano **Krakatoa** erupts and kills around 40,000; destroys island of Krakatoa, and causes tsunamis; explosion heard 3,000 miles (5,000 km) away

**July 5, 1884** Germany claims **Cameroon**

**March 13, 1884** Siege of **Khartoum**, Sudan, by Mahdi troops begins (to January 26, 1885)

**1884** Coup in **Korea** staged with Japan's aid, put down with aid of **China**

**1884** Berlin Conference on African Affairs (to 1885) leads to "Scramble for Africa"

**1884** Germany acquires **Togo** and **Cameroon**

**October 1884** Greenwich Meridian designated as Prime Meridian at international conference

**December 1884** Porfirio Díaz returns as president of **Mexico**